Brushstroke

By John Shanahan

Scene: Gavin Taylor, a neatly dressed man in his thirties to forties, stands at C, looking with some degree of awe over a large contemporary painting. (The painting's presence at C front should only be suggested.) It's a modern piece, many bold swaths and smaller strokes across the canvas. To anyone but Timothy, it would appear quite finished. To one side is a small table holding a palette with blobs of paint on it and several brushes. Upstage, slouched in a chair rubbing his eyes, is Timothy Parsons, the artist. He can be any age from late-twenties to fifties. He's dressed in a casual, artsy style, but his clothes are not the paint-spattered kind typically used to say "artist." He hasn't painted in so much as a dot in the last three weeks.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: How do you view art? It used to be that anything called "Art" had certain meaning attached to it. Art was assumed to be beautiful, intricate, expensive. . . crafted with care by a master. Sometimes it told a story, or marked a special day or event.

ACTOR 2: Art was universally revered, instantly recognized, and generally approached with awe, while today it is looked at much differently.

ACTOR 1: Viewers generally respond to works of art in one of the three following ways: Enjoyment, Dislike or Disinterest

ACTOR 2: Unfortunately, with art being as commonplace as it is, many artists and art experts are looking more and more for uniqueness in art above anything else. The art community tends to move from artist to artist, always searching for the cutting edge, the most daring, the strangest, even the obscene or shocking.

ACTOR 1: It is little wonder that for some artists, the mere act of completing a canvas is the cause for much trepidation as shown in

TOGETHER: Brushstroke by John Shanahan.

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GAVIN: **(Pg 131-138)** My. Timothy, oh my.

TIM: *(Without looking.)* Mm hmm.

GAVIN: This is ... magnificent.

TIM: Hmm.

GAVIN: I mean it's - I hate to sound gushy, but ... it's so powerful. Stunning.

TIM: You think so, huh?

GAVIN: *(Crossing back toward Tim.)* I really do.

TIM: Huh.

GAVIN: Don't you think so?

TIM: I wouldn't know.

GAVIN: *(Laughing.)* The artist wouldn't know if his work was good?

TIM: *(Flatly.)* It's hard to say until it's finished. *(Pause. Gavin looks at Tim, then to the painting, then back to Tim.)*

GAVIN: It's not done?

TIM: *(With some exhaustion.)* No. It's not done.

GAVIN: Really? Because, you know, it honestly is quite –

TIM: It's not done. *(A tense pause.)*

GAVIN: You could have fooled me.

TIM: Apparently I did.

GAVIN: Not done.

TIM: No.

GAVIN: How much longer do you figure before it is?

TIM: Hard to say.

GAVIN: How long has it been like this? Unfinished.

TIM: Three weeks, maybe.

GAVIN: Ah. *(He takes a few steps back and studies the painting.)* You've made a good start.

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TIM: Very funny.

GAVIN: SO what is it missing? What is it going to take to finish it?

TIM: One brushstroke. *(Silence. Gavin looks at Timothy with a question on his lips.)*

TIM: One brushstroke. Then it's done.

GAVIN: Are you serious?

TIM: *(Crossing past him to regard the painting.)* Quite.

GAVIN: So you could finish it today. Now.

TIM: No.

GAVIN: No? *(Timothy looks at the painting. Cocks his head. Shakes his head and walks back to the chair and sits wearily.)*

TIM: No.

GAVIN: You're beginning to worry me, Timothy.

TIM: Imagine how I feel. *(Pause. Gavin regards Timothy, as if to gauge if he's serious. To some degree, Gavin [eels that he's not. He picks up a brush from the table, walks back to Timothy, and holds it out to him.)*

GAVIN: Finish it. *(Pause')* Come on, just finish it, then we'll go have a drink to celebrate. I'm buying.

TIM: Just like that?

GAVIN: Come on. One brushstroke and be done with it!

TIM: Where does it go? *(Pause')* If it's so patently simple, Gavin, then help me out here. Where is it supposed to go?

GAVIN: It's not my work.

TIM: No, no, no, no - you don't back out like that. You don't just merrily tell me to pick up my brush and finish my painting and then say you don't know how.

GAVIN: But I -

TIM: Come on! Tell me where it goes! Tell me how to finish it! *(He snatches the brush from Gavin and waves it at the canvas.)* Does it go here? Huh? Up in this corner?

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No? The middle? Where, Gavin? Show me exactly where! How long should it be? How wide? Do you know? And what color? Is it brown? Is it sort of brown? Is it blue, Gavin? Is it? What if it's not blue, Gavin? What then? WHAT IF IT'S NOT SUPPOSED TO BE BLUE? *(He throws the brush down, storms across stage, and kicks the chair. He stands with his back to Gavin.) (A lengthy, tense silence.)*

GAVIN: I didn't want - I meant no disrespect, Timothy.

TIM: I know.

GAVIN: Do you want to talk about it? *(Timothy thinks a moment. He crosses to the brush, wherever it is, picks it up and puts it back on the table with the palette.)*

TIM: Probably. And I probably should. But to tell you the truth, I'm not sure I'd know what to say.

GAVIN: Just tell me what's going on. *(Timothy turns and smiles at him, but it's a sharp smile, almost a smirk.)*

TIM: That's what I like about you, Gavin. You have this firm, simple belief in the absolute black and whiteness of things. You genuinely believe that whatever's happening with me not finishing this can just be drawn out somehow by you asking me what's going on. That there's got to be this one thing that constitutes the entire problem.

GAVIN: *(Simply.)* Isn't there? *(Pause)*

GAVIN: Has anyone else seen this?

TIM: No.

GAVIN: Then why is it so bothersome that I, being the first person to find out that one brushstroke has kept you from finishing a great painting, should ask what's wrong?

TIM: I never said bothersome –

GAVIN: Then what?

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TIM: It's not that simple!

GAVIN: Why?

TIM: Why do you need to know? *(Gavin laughs)*

GAVIN: Because you're my friend, Timothy. Because I come here and I find you in this mood, with this problem, and - I'm honestly surprised that you have to ask me why I need to know! Why couldn't you have just said it's not done and left it at that? Or told me that it *was* done? Or hidden the damn thing in the first place? *(Timothy is at a loss.)*

GAVIN: Because you couldn't. Because you needed someone to know. You wanted someone to ask. Here I am.

TIM: Here you are.

GAVIN: And I'm asking.

TIM: Yes you are. *(Another silence. Gavin is determined to ride it out, to have Timothy speak first. After several beats, Timothy sighs.)*

TIM: Would you say, Gavin, that this is the best work I've ever done?

GAVIN: I'd have to say it's definitely on par with-

TIM: If you want to help me, Gavin, then answer the question. And it's a yes or no question. Is this the best work I've ever done?

GAVIN: You say it's not done.

TIM: You didn't know that when you first saw it. You told me it was stunning.

GAVIN: Well it is!

TIM: So is this my best work?

GAVIN: Yes. Probably.

TIM: Probably means no.

GAVIN: All right. Yes.

TIM: Exactly.

GAVIN: Exactly *what?*

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TIM: This may very well be my best.

GAVIN: Well, then, congratulations! *(Pause. A short, sad laugh .from Timothy.)*

TIM: I don't know why I thought you'd see it. I don't - *(He's at a loss. He throws his hands up.)*

GAVIN: What? *(He throws his hands up, mocking Timothy.)* What is *this? (A moment where Timothy's anger builds. Then he storms to the canvas.)*

TIM: This *is* my best painting. And the minute I take up that brush and I put that one final smear of paint, that line, that dot, whatever it is that finishes it, on that canvas, I will be *expected* to create another one that is better than this. My best. *(Calming in voice but not in mindset.)* If I finish this right now, then tomorrow or the next day or a year from now there will be a blank canvas - waiting - and from the first brushstroke, the first choice of color, it has to be better than this. But it has to come from somewhere. What if I don't have anything left after this?

GAVIN: Timothy. Really. This is just not sensible. This is just some sort of artistic post-partum depression. Art is a birthing process. I know that. You carry it around, you nurture it, and when it's done you have to separate from it, and I understand that can be difficult. Timothy, you're a brilliant artist. You don't need to worry that you won't have another idea.

TIM: "Idea." Your understanding is that this is me worrying about having an idea.

GAVIN: *(Smiling.)* Correct me if I'm wrong. *(Pause, as Timothy debates whether to go forward)*

TIM: I started planning this painting eleven months ago. At the time, I thought it was simply going to be my next painting. Just my next one. But as I worked on it, I knew it was becoming something, but not like before. I became very particular about it. And I got to this point, where it is now. Really about eight months of actual work - sketching, painting, refining everything. One morning

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I came out to work and ... I saw something. I saw every day of those eight months, all tied together on the canvas. I saw moments. I looked into it, I touched it. I started to think about what each pass of the brush meant. I wondered. Where were the bits that I painted when I was happy? When I was pissed off? Where I was invigorated? Where I was frustrated? What parts did I paint in the day? Which were those ones where I woke up in the middle of the night just knowing that I had to paint - those ideas that just come and won't go away? Where were the things that I'd painted over? What had *they* meant, where had *they* come from? Where did all of *this* come from? *(Pause)* And then, in this one moment, I understood. In one way or another, I put everything I am *(Touching the canvas.)* here. Almost everything. *(Without turning.)* And I am scared, Gavin, scared to death to think that when I put that one final stroke on this canvas, that I will have finally given everything that I am, and that it will be all that I have. I am afraid, Gavin, that in a very real way, I will disappear.

GAVIN: Nothing left, or nothing left to give?

TIM: They're the same.

GAVIN: Don't you wonder, though?

TIM: Wonder what?

GAVIN: What comes next, of course?

TIM: Yes, I do. And it scares the shit out of me.

GAVIN: Then it must be art.

TIM: What? *(Gavin picks up the palette and brusb.)*

GAVIN: One brushstroke. Then there's either something or there's nothing. But either way, there's art. Which is more than most people can say. Eight months you worked on this?

TIM: Yes.

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GAVIN: Then what's one more day's work? *(He holds the palette out to Timothy. Pause.)*

GAVIN: Not knowing will kill you. *(A beat. Timothy reluctantly steps over toward Gavin. He looks at the painting, then takes the palette. He turns back to the canvas, staring intently into it)*

GAVIN: Do you mind if I watch?

TIM: *(Snapping his attention away.)* What?

GAVIN: Can I watch you finish it?

TIM: Certainly. Yes. Please. *(Timothy hesitates. He looks at the palette, the brush poised above it. Then, without turning:)*

TIM: Gavin?

GAVIN: Yes?

TIM: What color is the last part of my soul?

GAVIN: *(After a beat.)* Timothy, you've known what color it is for the last three weeks. *(Timothy turns and looks at him.)* Paint it. *(Timothy turns back, and looks once more at the palette. He begins mixing colors as the lights fade.)*

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